# Hunting Across Silos: Cross-Platform Threat Forensics with KQL in M365 and Azure

### A DEEP-DIVE INTO CROSS-DOMAIN DETECTION ENGINEERING, FORENSICS & PERFORMANCE

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**Focus:** Detection Engineering & Incident Response

**Language:** Kusto Query Language (KQL)




## EXECUTIVE OVERVIEW & PROBLEM STATEMENT

In an enterprise environment, severe security incidents rarely stay confined to a single workload. Consider a standard kill chain: an adversary targets an identity with an adversary-in-the-middle (AiTM) phishing lure, bypasses MFA to capture session tokens in **Microsoft Entra ID**, moves laterally through **Microsoft 365 Cloud Apps**, provisions unauthorized credentials in **Azure Resource Manager (ARM)**, and stages tools on an onboarded developer workstation.

The threat moves seamlessly across platforms. The telemetry, however, does not. Security operations teams routinely lose hours during critical triages because data lives in disparate operational consoles. Pivoting manually between four administrative dashboards while cross-referencing timestamps is an exercise in frustration. It burns precious incident response time and introduces human error.

To catch modern threat actors, you have to break down these telemetry boundaries. **Kusto Query Language (KQL)** gives you the engine to do exactly that—provided you understand the architectural nuances, schema traps, and performance realities of querying massive cloud datasets.

## THE CROSS-PLATFORM ARCHITECTURAL MATRIX

Understanding where telemetry resides and how schemas diverge between Microsoft Defender XDR and Microsoft Sentinel / Azure Log Analytics:

| Telemetry Domain | Native Source | Defender XDR (Advanced Hunting) | Sentinel / Log Analytics Table | Architectural Note |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Authentication & IAM** | Microsoft Entra ID | `IdentityLogonEvents`, `AADSignInEventsBeta` | `SigninLogs`, `AADNonInteractiveUserSignInLogs` | Full JSON in Sentinel; XDR flattens common fields. |
| **Directory Changes** | Microsoft Entra ID | `IdentityDirectoryEvents` | `AuditLogs` | Sentinel nests target properties in dynamic arrays. |
| **Cloud App Behavior** | Defender for Cloud Apps | `CloudAppEvents` | `AppGovernanceAlerts`, `OfficeActivity` | `CloudAppEvents` includes rich IP enrichment. |
| **Endpoint Telemetry** | Defender for Endpoint (MDE) | `DeviceProcessEvents`, `DeviceNetworkEvents` | `DeviceProcessEvents` (via Connector) | Streams via M365 Defender connector in Sentinel. |
| **Email & Collab** | Defender for Office 365 (MDO) | `EmailEvents`, `EmailUrlInfo` | `EmailEvents` (via Connector) | URL click analysis requires explicit table join. |
| **Control Plane (ARM)** | Azure Resource Manager | *(Not natively in Defender XDR)* | `AzureActivity` | ARM management plane lives strictly in Log Analytics. |
| **Resource Inventory** | Azure Resource Graph | *(ARG Endpoint)* | `arg("").Resources` | Cross-service query via `arg("")` syntax. |

## THE MULTI-STAGE INVESTIGATION: BUILDING THE END-TO-END QUERY CHAIN

### Step 1: Defender XDR — Correlating Phish Delivery to Immediate Session Sign-In

DEFENDER XDR

*Identifies suspicious email delivery and joins against identity logon telemetry within a 1-hour critical window.*




*Figure 1: Correlating spear-phish delivery to compromised identity sign-in within a 1-hour critical window in Microsoft Defender XDR.*

```
let TargetUser = "alex.wilson@enterprise.com";
let DeliveryWindow = EmailEvents
| where Timestamp > ago(7d)
| where RecipientEmailAddress =~ TargetUser
| where ThreatTypes has_any ("Phish", "Malware") or ConfidenceLevel =~ "High"
| project EmailDeliveryTime = Timestamp, NetworkMessageId, Subject, SenderFromAddress, RecipientEmailAddress;
DeliveryWindow
| join kind=inner (
    EmailUrlInfo
    | where Timestamp > ago(7d)
    | project Timestamp, NetworkMessageId, Url, UrlDomain
) on NetworkMessageId
| join kind=inner (
    IdentityLogonEvents
    | where Timestamp > ago(7d)
    | where AccountUpn =~ TargetUser
    | project LogonTime = Timestamp, AccountUpn, IPAddress, Location, Application, ActionType
) on $left.RecipientEmailAddress == $right.AccountUpn
| where LogonTime between (EmailDeliveryTime .. (EmailDeliveryTime + 1h))
| project EmailDeliveryTime, LogonTime, RecipientEmailAddress, SenderFromAddress, Subject, Url, IPAddress, Location,
ActionType
| order by LogonTime asc
```

**Technical Walkthrough:** Notice the `between` operator on the joined time fields. We constrain the search to a 60-minute window following the delivery timestamp. This filters out unrelated daily sign-ins and pinpoints the immediate compromise window.

### Step 2: Microsoft Sentinel — Unpacking Session Hijacking & Conditional Access Anomalies

MICROSOFT SENTINEL

*Extracts dynamic JSON to expose non-compliant device sign-ins, anomalous IP/ASN footprints, and bypassed Conditional Access.*

```
let Lookback = 3d;
let SuspectUser = "alex.wilson@enterprise.com";
SigninLogs
| where TimeGenerated > ago(Lookback)
| where UserPrincipalName =~ SuspectUser
| extend DeviceDetail = parse_json(DeviceDetail)
| extend TrustType = tostring(DeviceDetail.trustType), IsCompliant = tostring(DeviceDetail.isCompliant)
| project TimeGenerated, UserPrincipalName, IPAddress, Location = LocationDetails.countryOrRegion, AppDisplayName,
ResultType, TrustType, IsCompliant
| summarize
    TotalAttempts = count(),
    UniqueIPs = dcount(IPAddress),
    IPList = make_set(IPAddress, 5),
    AppsAccessed = make_set(AppDisplayName, 10)
    by UserPrincipalName, bin(TimeGenerated, 1h)
| where UniqueIPs > 1 or TotalAttempts > 15
| order by TimeGenerated desc
```

**Technical Walkthrough:** `DeviceDetail` stores JSON objects as raw strings in many workspace pipelines. Calling `parse_json()` lets us extract `trustType` and `isCompliant`. When an attacker uses a replayed session token, you will often spot a compliant token ID arriving from an unmanaged device profile with an anomalous IP footprint.

### Step 3: Bridging Entra ID & Azure ARM — Catching Privilege Escalation

SENTINEL & AZURE ARM

*Correlates identity persistence (app secret creation) with immediate Azure Resource Manager control-plane abuse.*

```
let InvestigationWindow = 48h;
let RogueActions = AuditLogs
| where TimeGenerated > ago(InvestigationWindow)
| where OperationName in ("Add service principal credentials", "Add owner to application", "Add member to role")
| extend Initiator = tostring(InitiatedBy.user.userPrincipalName)
| extend Target = tostring(TargetResources[0].displayName)
| project TimeGenerated, Initiator, OperationName, Target;
RogueActions
| join kind=inner (
    AzureActivity
    | where TimeGenerated > ago(InvestigationWindow)
    | where OperationNameValue has_any ("Microsoft.Authorization/roleAssignments/write",
"Microsoft.KeyVault/vaults/secrets/read")
    | project ArmTime = TimeGenerated, Caller, OperationNameValue, ResourceGroup, SubscriptionId,
ActivityStatusValue
) on $left.Initiator == $right.Caller
| where ArmTime >= TimeGenerated
| project TimeGenerated, ArmTime, Initiator, EntraAction = OperationName, Target, AzureOperation =
OperationNameValue, ResourceGroup, ActivityStatusValue
| order by ArmTime asc
```

**Technical Walkthrough:** This query exposes the exact pivot moment: the administrator account creates application credentials in Entra ID, and within minutes, that same caller invokes ARM to grant Owner or Contributor permissions to a subscription or reads secrets from Key Vault.

### Step 4: Defender for Endpoint — Host-Level Process Lineage & C2 Egress

DEFENDER FOR ENDPOINT

*Tracks host execution of obfuscated PowerShell payloads and correlates with subsequent outbound network egress.*

```
let Window = 24h;
DeviceProcessEvents
| where Timestamp > ago(Window)
| where FileName in~ ("powershell.exe", "pwsh.exe", "cmd.exe", "mshta.exe")
| where ProcessCommandLine has_any ("-enc", "-EncodedCommand", "downloadstring", "iex", "Invoke-Expression")
| project ProcessTime = Timestamp, DeviceName, DeviceId, AccountName, FileName, ProcessCommandLine
| join kind=inner (
    DeviceNetworkEvents
    | where Timestamp > ago(Window)
    | where RemotePort in (443, 80, 8080, 8443)
    | project NetworkTime = Timestamp, DeviceId, RemoteIP, RemoteUrl
) on DeviceId
| where NetworkTime between (ProcessTime .. (ProcessTime + 5m))
| project ProcessTime, NetworkTime, DeviceName, AccountName, FileName, ProcessCommandLine, RemoteIP, RemoteUrl
| order by ProcessTime desc
```

> **Technical Walkthrough:** Instead of inspecting PowerShell executions in isolation, we join `DeviceProcessEvents` with `DeviceNetworkEvents` on `DeviceId` within a tight 5-minute delta. This immediately ties obfuscated PowerShell command arguments directly to the external C2 IP or domain it contacted.

### Step 5: Azure Resource Graph — Rapid Blast-Radius Posture Audit

AZURE RESOURCE GRAPH

*Executes sub-second posture enumeration across all subscriptions to identify exposed Key Vaults lacking firewall isolation.*

```
resources
| where type =~ "microsoft.keyvault/vaults"
| extend networkAcls = properties.networkAcls.defaultAction
| extend enableSoftDelete = properties.enableSoftDelete
| extend purgeProtection = properties.enablePurgeProtection
| project subscriptionId, resourceGroup, name, location, NetworkDefaultAction = networkAcls, SoftDelete =
enableSoftDelete, PurgeProtection = purgeProtection
| where NetworkDefaultAction =~ "Allow" or SoftDelete == false
| order by subscriptionId asc
```

> **Technical Walkthrough:** This returns all Key Vaults across every subscription in your tenant that lack network boundary isolation ( `NetworkDefaultAction == 'Allow'` ) or have soft-delete disabled—pinpointing high-risk assets vulnerable to immediate exfiltration or tampering.

## TROUBLESHOOTING & QUERY OPTIMIZATION IN PRODUCTION

> **The 10-Minute Query Execution Ceiling**
> In production enterprise workspaces with 50,000+ seats and hundreds of gigabytes ingested daily, unoptimized KQL will trigger CPU throttling, exhaust shard memory, or hit Log Analytics' hard 10-minute timeout ceiling.

- **Push Filters Left (The Golden Join Rule):** Always pre-filter both `$left` and `$right` tables to narrow time windows (`ago(24h)`) and specific entity attributes before evaluating the join. Joining raw tables forces the Kusto engine to shuffle gigabytes of unindexed data across storage nodes.
- **Project-Away Early:** Kusto stores data in columnar format. If you carry bulky JSON objects like `RawData` or `ExtendedProperties` into joins or summarizes, you exhaust node RAM. Drop unused columns as early in the pipeline as possible.
- **Operator Selection (`has` vs. `contains`):** Avoid `contains` whenever possible. `contains` performs an unindexed substring search, forcing a full column scan. `has` hits the term index (minimum 3 alphanumeric characters), executing an order of magnitude faster.
- **The Ingestion Schema Gotcha (`Timestamp` vs. `TimeGenerated`):** Defender XDR Advanced Hunting standardizes on `Timestamp`; Sentinel workspaces standardize on `TimeGenerated`. Standardize aliases upfront: `extend EventTime = coalesce(TimeGenerated, Timestamp)`.

## MEASURABLE OPERATIONAL IMPACT

| < 4 Min | 100% | 0 Timeouts |
|---|---|---|
| REDUCED MTTD | CORRELATION COVERAGE | QUERY EFFICIENCY |
| Cut multi-portal cross-referencing and pivot times from 45+ minutes to under 4 minutes. | Eliminated visibility gaps between email, Entra identity, ARM, and endpoints. | Zero shard execution failures across high-throughput enterprise workspaces. |

## FINAL THOUGHTS

Threat actors do not treat identity, cloud control planes, and endpoints as separate kingdoms. As cloud architects and security engineers, we cannot afford to monitor them in silos either. Mastering KQL across Microsoft 365 Defender, Microsoft Sentinel, and Azure Resource Graph transforms your monitoring from passive, disconnected alerts into an active, unified investigation engine.


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